LCDs are fast becoming the display solution of choice for most offices, due to their size, elegant looks, and the fall in prices over the last couple of years.

LCD prices have dropped 25 per cent in the last one year or so. Due to this, some major PC vendors have started bundling LCDs with their PCs, particularly Zenith, HP and HCL. This has created more awareness amongst the buyers, and caused more vendors to jump the bandwagon—D-Link, Umax and CMV have launched their monitors in the past few months. Certain brands, such as Sony and Acer, have pulled out of the CRT segment altogether, and are concentrating solely on LCDs.

The entry level LCDs are available at a price tag of Rs 18,000 upwards. Sharp has a large product range with around 17 monitors catering to all kinds of users ranging from Rs 24,000 for the home segment, to Rs 1,00,000 and beyond for the money-is-no-object segment.

How we tested

In the LCD comparison test, we again evaluated the performance, features, value for money and warranty details. The performance was evaluated using the same tests as the CRTs. LCDS were additionally tested for jerks or image blurring. We also looked for features such as the various accessories bundled, the design, look and feel, the placement of buttons, whether one could adjust the height, and other little extras—such as USB ports, DVI connectors etc.

15-inch monitors The Sync Master 152S was one of the most elegantly designed LCD monitors in the test, with a choice of silver, or carbon black colours. We received a silver LCD monitor, and it blew the competition away in the looks department. The front face has five buttons for configuring the screen and using the OSD, and also an auto configure button. This monitor can be wall mounted, and also comes with an adjustable height stand. Various accessories, such as a power adapter, colour calibrating software and wall mounting accessories are bundled with it. The only sore point was the absence of DVI support. At 2.9 Kg, it was the lightest monitor in its category.

On the other hand, the AL 511, which is the latest offering from Acer, was the cheapest in the entire 15-inches LCD category. The design is very simple, with a white plastic body. The OSD menu is quite detailed, with lot of options, but is too complicated to use. The AL 511 lacks many features, such as built-in speakers, wall mounting and height adjustment—but it has a 60 degree tilt angle for easy viewing. Also at 3.2 Kg, it was one of the lighter LCDs in this category.

The Sharp LL T15G3 is one of the most space saving LCD monitors in its category. The design is quite simple, and it is available in white and black options. The LL T15G3 comes with five buttons for screen configuration, including one auto configuration button. Other interesting options, such as Auto-Gain, can also be set. The screen can be tilted 60 degrees for easier viewing, and can also be wall mounted. This LCD does not come with speakers, which is the only dissapointment, but has the manual, drivers, and a signal cable bundled along.

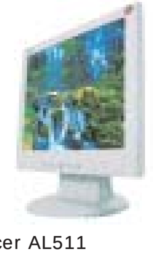
The Samsung Sync Master 151MP was the most feature-rich LCD in the 15-inch category. Boasting of HDTV and TV tuning capabilities, it certainly stands out from

The Mystique of the LCD

Why are LCDs so costly, if they are smaller in size, and use less power? The reason is their high rate of failure during manufacturing. As every pixel has individually controlled transistors that switch on and off, manufacturing calls for a higher degree of precision—which becomes a much greater challenge as compared to CRT manufacturing. There is certain level of quality control adopted by every manufacturer while fabricating LCDs. Therefore, a large numbers of fabricated LCDs are rejected during quality control check because of high dead pixel count, (malfunctioning transistors). These screens have to be discarded and the costs are passed on to the consumer.

Due to this high failure rate, most companies do not consider three or less dead pixels to be a defect—but, as a user you should watch out for this. Also, as the screen size increases, the number of dead pixels increase—hence the yield takes a nose dive, which further inflates the cost of large screen LCDs.

The current LCD manufacturing technique is similar to applying paint to a wall with a roller. Companies such as IBM have researched alternatives to this unreliable technique. The new technique uses electrically charged atoms to position the transistors, hence increasing the accuracy of crystal placing and lowering the failure rate. A very fine layer of carbon is spread over the LCD-to-be and then an ion-gun is used to shoot aside the surface carbon atoms, hence forming rows on which the transistors can be precisely placed. This technique now awaits adoption by various LCD vendors. The faster they implement this technique the better.



Acer AL511
+ Light weight
- No built in speakers and wall mounting

CMV 1512
+ Overall good performance; Light weight; High luminance
- NA

CMV 1515
+ Good luminance
- NA

Digiview DGL 115SP
+ Good performance
- NA

HCL HCM 500 LSA
+ Good refresh rates
- Poor performance